

CULTURAL DIVERSITY

Cultural diversity is the quality of diverse or different cultures, as opposed to monoculture, the global monoculture, or a homogenization of cultures, akin to cultural evolution. The term "cultural diversity" can also refer to having different cultures respect each other's differences.

Definition:

Dr. Caleb Rosado, defines cultural diversity as *"...a system of beliefs and behaviors that recognizes and respects the presence of all diverse groups in an organization or society, acknowledges and values their socio-cultural differences, and encourages and enables their continued contribution within an inclusive cultural context which empowers all within the organization or society."*

Explanation:

Essentially, cultural diversity is about bringing people together from a diverse set of backgrounds and cultures, then creating an environment that not only recognizes the differences between those cultures and backgrounds, but celebrates them. It helps create a safe space for people to be authentically themselves.

Diversity refers to the attributes that people use to confirm themselves with respect to others, "that person is different from me." These attributes include demographic factors (such as race, gender, and age) as well as values and cultural norms. The many separate societies that emerged around the globe differ markedly from each other, and many of these differences persist to this day. The more obvious cultural differences that exist between people are language, dress, and traditions. There are also significant variations in the way societies organize themselves, such as in their shared conception of morality, religious belief, and in the ways, they interact with their environment. Cultural diversity can be seen as analogous to biodiversity.

Cultural diversity is found among people on the basis of following dimensions:

Race, Ethnicity, Sexual orientation, Religion, Language, Gender, Age, and Disability.

The importance of cultural diversity can be interpreted on the basis of these related actions:

- Recognizing that there is a large amount of cultures that exist
- Respecting each other's differences
- Acknowledging that all cultural expressions are valid
- Valuing what cultures have to bring to the table
- Empowering diverse groups to contribute



- Celebrating differences, not just tolerating them
- Cultural diversity looks like this:

Benefits of Cultural Diversity

The world is naturally multicultural. Approaching cultural diversity with a mindset and actions that embrace this fact leads to many benefits, like:

- **Compassion:** Communication and understanding of differences leads to increased compassion instead of judgment.
- **Innovation:** Varied perspectives and lens of looking at the world lend to innovative thinking.
- **Productivity:** People who come together and bring their own style of working together tend to support a more productive team.
- **New Opportunities:** The diversity opens the door to new opportunities and the blending of ideas which would otherwise have been homogeneous.
- **Problem-Solving:** Challenges are layered, so having people with different backgrounds can lead to better problem-solving with richness of opinions.

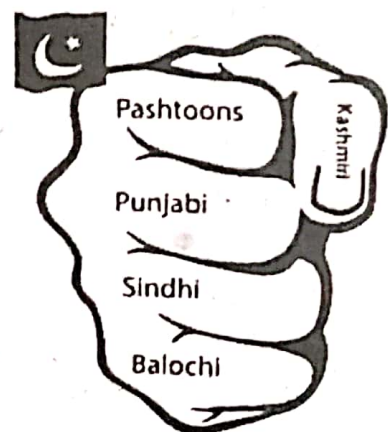
SUB-CULTURE

According to John J. Maccionis: *"cultural patterns that set apart some segment of a society's population."*

Explanation:

In one society, there may be a number of regional classes representing their respective ways of life distinctive from one another and from the whole culture. The culture of these classes of people, within the general culture of the whole society, is called sub-culture. For example, culture of Pakistani society has several sub-cultures in its various regions. Panjabi, Sindhi, Balochi and Pukhtoon people have their respective cultures different from one another and distinctive from the total culture of Pakistani society.

This Is Pakistan. 🇵🇰



Punjabi culture, however, is a part-culture contributing to the whole of Pakistani culture. Within one region, take for example, in Punjab there are a number of sub-cultural groups such as Lahori, Saraiki, Gujrati and Pothohari. These sub-cultures represent their respective distinction of local dialects in speech, terms of addressing others, styles of dresses and certain customary ways at the occasions of birth and marriage. There are numerous sub-cultures in one culture, on the basis of geographical, religious, economic and ancestral conditions. Sub-cultures are really the integral parts of the total culture and without that part the whole is not completed. The sub-culture is interrelated with, or interdependent upon the rest of the culture. With the exclusion of sub-cultures the whole cannot represent its entity.

Basis of Subculture

According to Sutherland, Woodward and Maxwell, the main sub-cultures are:

- regional sub-culture,
- ethnic or nationality sub-cultures,
- urban and rural sub-cultures,
- class sub-culture, occupational sub-culture, and
- the religious sub-culture.

Cultural Relativism

If we try to understand a foreign culture in terms of our values and motives, we will not be able to do so. Because our values and motives will bias our observation and our judgment will not be real. We must interpret and describe their behavior in the light of their motives, habits and values, if we are to understand them. It means to understand the society of a foreign culture we will have to apply the modes of the same society. For this purpose, a sociologist is required to undergo changes in his attitudes, motives, values and habits according to the social systems of the society which he wants to study. It is a sort of training for him. He must set his values aside and learn the habits and motives of the people of the new society.

Definition:

According to John J. Maccionis: *the practice of judging a culture by its own standards.*

Horton and Hunt: *"the function and meaning of a trait are relative to its cultural setting is called cultural diversity"*.

A trait is neither good nor bad but it is good, or bad only with reference to the culture in which it functions. The rite of Sati in Hindus and custom of Polyandry in Tibetans are its examples. The Hindus worship the sun, the river Ganges and the idols. These items of worship are fitted in Hindu culture. From these examples, we note that any cultural trait is socially "good" if it operates harmoniously within its cultural setting to attain the goals which the people are seeking.

ETHNOCENTRISM

Definition:

Sumner defined ethnocentrism as *"that view of things in which ones', own group is the center of everything and all others are scaled and rated with reference to it."*

Horton and Hunt deduce that *"ethnocentrism is the habit of every group of taking for granted the superiority of its culture"*.

Explanation:

It means that every culture considers itself superior to other cultures. The Americans think of themselves as the "Progressive" while the Eastern cultures call them immoral. The Pakistanis call themselves as brave, hard-worker and faithful people. The Arabs call themselves hospitable. Similarly, the people of every nation feel pride and claim superiority upon other nations. This sense of pride or superiority upon others is called ethnocentrism.

Even within a society different social groups are ethnocentric against one another. The agriculturists claim to be superior to laborers and the businessmen are proud upon low class servants. Similarly, high class officers think themselves higher upon other low class servants. This feeling of superiority upon others is universal among nations, groups and the individuals. This cultural trait is called ethnocentrism.

Positive Effects of Ethnocentrism

1. It encourages social solidarity in groups and in society by which the forces of co-operation become stronger.

2. It provides protection to group members by creating sense of belonging among them. Those members who are weak, poor, hopeless and helpless are encouraged by joining hands of ethnocentrism with them. It means it provides compensation to the people of low status.
3. It promotes nationalism and patriotism among the members of society. Because it stimulates the spirit of belonging to the society and culture claiming superiority to others.
4. Caste, Biradri and consanguine groups develop by ethnocentrism in which marriage and other social relations are facilitated.

Negative Effects of Ethnocentrism

1. Ethnocentrism creates tight boundaries among various social groups. The inter-group relations are hampered due to prejudice against one another. The process of social relations among various groups gets slower.
2. The prejudice created by ethnocentrism creates conflict and tension among various groups. The social forces of cooperation face problems in their operation.
3. Ethnocentrism limits an individual in a small social group to which he belongs. He remains within the limits of that group and is not influenced by the general social changes happening around him in the society. He remains backward in a sense by this way and adopts little changes. Sometimes even he preaches against modern social changes. It means it discourages culture change among the people.
4. The national development in general is slowed down in such cultures where ethnocentrism is emphasized in books, newspapers, radio and television.